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Payment card data: an opportunity for security

issues are perceived to be more urgent, or more critical to the business.

In fact, an IBM report published last year indicates that data breaches cost organizations Rs 14 crore on an average, and that these breaches have increased by 9.4% since 2019. It is therefore clear that this is a growing problem that needs to be addressed.

It takes 280 days to identify and contain a data breach – which is more than 9 months where cyber-criminals have unfettered access to compromised systems which can have significant financial consequences for a business. To better combat cyber-crime, businesses require the appropriate training to ensure that their staff are aware of the risks associated with cyber-attacks, and the steps to take to better protect their business from security breaches.

The future of the digital payments ecosystem is bright, but as technology evolves so must the security solutions that protect cardholder data being used to make payments over an increasingly diverse range of channels. To help support this need, PCI develops security standards and guidance to help businesses make the most of these new technologies such as their PCI Contactless Payments on COTS (CPoC) Solutions, which helps enable contactless payment acceptance using NFC technology, or their Point-to-Point Encryption (P2PE) Solutions. The ability to securely use the latest payments technology will be a key aspect in the road ahead for payment card data security in India.

As well as catering for the uptake of newer technologies, another most anticipated development in payment card data security is the introduction of PCI Data Security Standards (DSS) version 4.0 which aims to (1) ensure that the security standards continue to meet the security needs of the payments industry, (2) add flexibility and support

for additional methodologies to achieve security, and (3) promote security as a continuous process and enhances validation methods and procedures.

The PCI DSS v4.0 is evolving to introduce greater flexibility to support organizations using a broad range of controls and methods to meet security objectives. The updated version addresses changes in technology, risk mitigation techniques, and the threat landscape. Furthermore, since the methods of making and taking payments are becoming more advanced, such as with contactless payments, security standards will be more focused on securing the software enabled mobile payments infrastructure. PCI SSC continues to work on creating new and robust standards for the security of mobile and software-based payments. As these technologies evolve along with the developments in the areas of 5G and IoT, the industry will witness the council introducing new security standards and guidance resources for new and emerging card-routed payments channels.

For such monumental developments in the payments data security infrastructure, industry feedback is essential. For the past three years, PCI SSC has regularly spoken with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and other regulatory bodies, to work together in creating more awareness and education about security for payment card data. Furthermore, the feedback received from business and relevant stakeholders in India and around the world will continue to help the council evolve these security standards to better meet the needs of the industry.

It is clear that cybersecurity is a business imperative and critical for ensuring resilience, not just in times of crisis, but in day-to-day operations. Businesses need to do their part and ensure they are taking every necessary step to help combat cybercrime. 

With the increase in COVID-19 cases in India, the nation's digital way of life has been changing, especially when considering contactless and digital payments. This digitalization is also turning India into an increasingly attractive target for cybercriminals, which requires constant vigilance from business leaders to safeguard their customers' payment card data, and better protect their own organizations from financial damage.

The pandemic has provided cyber-criminals another avenue to target remote workers via phishing, malware, ransomware, and social engineering attacks (by exploiting businesses' COVID-19 response messaging). In fact, according to the 2021 Norton Cyber Safety Insights Report, nearly 120 million Indians experienced cybercrime between February 2020 – 2021. Moreover, approximately 1.3 billion working hours have been wasted in resolving issues caused by these attacks.

A recent report by Cybersecurity Ventures states that cybercrime is expected to reach \$6 trillion in damages in 2021, which makes it one of the greatest threats to economic success for businesses across the world.

In the payment card data ecosystem, it is vital that the security of cardholder data remains a top priority for businesses and every possible step is taken to combat cybercrime. However, data security is often neglected as other